

Wavelet Convolutions Are Memory-Bound: An I/O-Aware Formulation of WTConv

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Paper under double-blind review

Abstract

Wavelet convolution (WTConv) attains a receptive field that grows exponentially in the number of decomposition levels while its parameter count grows only linearly, and it drops into standard backbones without architectural change. Its reference implementation is nevertheless slower than the dense 7×7 convolution it is meant to replace, which has kept an asymptotically attractive operator practically unattractive. We show that this gap is not a constant-factor engineering artifact but a direct consequence of how the operator is expressed: WTConv performs $\mathcal{O}(1)$ arithmetic per element at an arithmetic intensity of 0.4–0.9 FLOP/byte, roughly two orders of magnitude below the balance point of a modern GPU, so its cost is determined almost entirely by data movement between stages that each round-trip through high-bandwidth memory. We give an exact I/O-complexity accounting of the operator, deriving that the reference form moves $7N + \frac{43}{3}N(1 - 4^{-L})$ elements, i.e. 17.8–21.3 N , for an input of $N = B \cdot C \cdot H \cdot W$ elements and L levels, against $2N$ of compulsory traffic, and we close most of that gap with three exact algebraic reformulations: the Haar analysis cascade is recomputed in registers at low arithmetic cost because the transform is multiplication-free; the L -level synthesis cascade collapses into a single closed-form pass across all levels whose sign pattern is indexed by the bits of the output coordinate, eliminating every intermediate low-pass plane; and the learned per-channel scale is folded into the convolution weights by linearity. Because the normalised Haar matrix satisfies $\mathbf{H} = \mathbf{H}^\top = \mathbf{H}^{-1}$, analysis and synthesis exchange roles during backpropagation, so no separate derivative of the Haar transform is needed. The resulting formulation is a bit-exact reassociation of the original operator, not an approximation, and it moves $7N$ elements at $L=1$ and under $8.3N$ for any L , a 2.5–2.6 $\times$ reduction in traffic. Latency is a separate question, which we treat separately: a CUDA realisation measures 2.24–2.89 $\times$ in **fp32** and up to 3.85 $\times$ in **fp16** against the reference. Because the argument is about data movement rather than any hardware feature, the same formulation transfers unchanged to Triton and to Apple Metal.

1 Introduction

Convolutional networks acquire large receptive fields slowly. Stacking 3×3 kernels grows the theoretical receptive field linearly in depth and the *effective* receptive field only as $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{n})$ (Luo et al., 2016), which is a large part of why vision transformers, whose first layer already mixes globally (Dosovitskiy et al., 2021; Liu et al., 2021), were initially so competitive. The convolutional response has been to enlarge kernels directly: 31×31 re-parameterised depthwise kernels (Ding et al., 2022), or 51×51 sparse factorised ones (Liu et al., 2023). Both buy receptive field at a parameter and FLOP cost that grows with the kernel area.

WTConv (Finder et al., 2024) takes a different route. It applies a small $k \times k$ depthwise kernel independently at each level of an L -level Haar decomposition. Because level ℓ operates on a 2^ℓ -times-downsampled grid, its footprint in input pixels is $k \cdot 2^\ell$, so an L -level layer reaches $k \cdot 2^L$ pixels using $\mathcal{O}(Lk^2C)$ parameters: the receptive field grows exponentially in L while parameters grow linearly, i.e. parameters grow only logarithmically in the receptive field. It is a drop-in replacement for depthwise convolutions and improves accuracy and robustness in ConvNeXt and MobileNetV2 backbones (Liu et al., 2022; Sandler et al., 2018).

There is a catch that the asymptotics hide. In the reference implementation, a WTConv layer is *slower than the dense 7×7 convolution it is supposed to replace*, by $1.14\text{--}1.65\times$ in our measurements. An operator that is cheaper in parameters and FLOPs but more expensive in wall-clock time is a poor trade in practice, and this is the gap we close.

The cost of WTConv is data movement, not arithmetic. Our starting observation is that WTConv is nowhere near compute-bound. Counting the multiply-accumulates the operator actually performs against the bytes its reference implementation actually moves gives an arithmetic intensity of $0.44\text{--}0.89$ FLOP/byte (Section 3). An NVIDIA RTX A6000 balances at roughly 50 FLOP/byte. The operator therefore sits two orders of magnitude to the left of the roofline ridge: the GPU spends essentially all of its time waiting for memory, and the arithmetic, including the Haar transform itself, is free in comparison. This reframes the problem. The question is not how to compute the wavelet transform faster; it is how to stop writing intermediate tensors to high-bandwidth memory (HBM). The same reframing drove FlashAttention (Dao et al., 2022), and the analogy is close: in both cases a mathematically elegant operator was expressed as a chain of memory-bound primitives, and in both cases the fix is a reassociation that keeps intermediates on chip.

What makes WTConv especially amenable. Two structural properties of the Haar basis make the reassociation unusually clean, and they are what we exploit.

Haar analysis has low arithmetic cost. The 2×2 transform uses only sums, differences, and fixed scaling by $\frac{1}{2}$. Recomputing its coefficients is therefore inexpensive compared with storing and reloading them. Longer wavelet filters would make this trade-off less favourable.

The normalised Haar operator is symmetric and self-inverse. With the $\frac{1}{2}$ normalisation, the 4×4 analysis matrix satisfies $\mathbf{H} = \mathbf{H}^\top = \mathbf{H}^{-1}$ exactly (Proposition 1). Consequently, analysis and synthesis exchange roles during backpropagation, and no separate derivative of the Haar transform is needed.

Contributions.

- **A cost model for WTConv** (Section 3). We give an exact element-by-element I/O accounting of the reference implementation: $Q_{\text{ref}} = 7N + \frac{43}{3}N(1 - 4^{-L})$. We place the operator on the roofline and show it is bandwidth-bound by two orders of magnitude.
- **An I/O-reduced reformulation** (Section 4) built from three exact algebraic identities (register-resident analysis, closed-form single-pass synthesis across all levels, and scale folding), reaching $7N$ at $L=1$ and at most $\approx 8.3N$ for any L , against $2N$ of compulsory traffic — a $2.5\text{--}2.6\times$ reduction in traffic across all levels. The synthesis collapse (Section 4.2) turns an L -level inverse cascade into a single closed-form pass whose per-level sign pattern is read off the bits of the output coordinate, eliminating all intermediate low-pass planes and sequential level dependencies uniformly across all levels.
- **Measurement** (Section B). A CUDA realisation measures $2.24\text{--}2.89\times$ in **fp32** and up to $3.85\times$ in **fp16** against the reference, and is faster than the dense 7×7 convolution WTConv is proposed to replace at every level. We report traffic and latency separately and do not claim a proportionality between them (Section 4.4).
- **Exactness, not approximation.** Every step is a reassociation of the same multilinear map, so agreement with the reference is limited only by floating-point reassociation error, which we quantify for the forward pass and for every gradient the layer produces.

We develop the argument for a single CUDA realisation to keep the exposition concrete. Because the reformulation is about data movement and not about any hardware feature, it transfers unchanged; we summarise Triton and Apple Metal realisations in Section C.

2 Background

2.1 The WTConv operator

Let $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{B \times C \times H \times W}$ denote the input, and let $N = B \cdot C \cdot H \cdot W$ be its element count, the unit in which we quote every I/O cost. Let $\ast_{\text{dw}}$ denote depthwise convolution (one $k \times k$ kernel per channel, zero-padded to preserve resolution) and let $\odot$ denote per-channel scaling.

Let $\mathcal{A}$ denote one level of Haar analysis, which splits each channel into four half-resolution subbands (LL, LH, HL, HH), and let $\mathcal{A}^\top$ denote its synthesis, which inverts it exactly (Proposition 1). For a tensor carrying a subband axis, let $[\cdot]_{\text{LL}}$ denote the low-pass band, $[\cdot]_{\text{H}}$ the three high-pass bands, and $\parallel$ their concatenation. WTConv preserves the channel count. It learns a $k \times k$ kernel and a per-channel scale at each level, $(\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}, \mathbf{s}^{(\ell)})$ for $\ell = 1, \dots, L$, together with a full-resolution base convolution $(\mathbf{W}^{(0)}, b, \mathbf{s}^{(0)})$, giving $\mathcal{O}(Lk^2C)$ parameters in total. Algorithm 1 states the operator as the reference implements it.

Algorithm 1 WTConv, reference form (Finder et al., 2024)

Require: input $\mathbf{X}$, levels L , parameters $\{\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)}, \mathbf{s}^{(\ell)}\}_{\ell=0}^L$, bias b

```

1:  $\mathbf{X}^{(0)} \leftarrow \mathbf{X}$                                  $\triangleright$  decomposition carrier
2: for  $\ell = 1, \dots, L$  do                             $\triangleright$  downward: decompose and filter
3:    $\mathbf{Y}^{(\ell)} \leftarrow \mathcal{A}\mathbf{X}^{(\ell-1)}$              $\triangleright$  Haar analysis
4:    $\mathbf{Z}^{(\ell)} \leftarrow \mathbf{s}^{(\ell)} \odot (\mathbf{Y}^{(\ell)} \ast_{\text{dw}} \mathbf{W}^{(\ell)})$   $\triangleright$  filter, then scale
5:    $\mathbf{X}^{(\ell)} \leftarrow [\mathbf{Y}^{(\ell)}]_{\text{LL}}$                  $\triangleright$  carry the raw, unfiltered low-pass band
6: end for
7:  $R^{(L+1)} \leftarrow 0$ 
8: for  $\ell = L, \dots, 1$  do                             $\triangleright$  upward: reconstruct and accumulate
9:    $R^{(\ell)} \leftarrow \mathcal{A}^\top \left( ([\mathbf{Z}^{(\ell)}]_{\text{LL}} + R^{(\ell+1)}) \parallel [\mathbf{Z}^{(\ell)}]_{\text{H}} \right)$ 
10: end for
11: return  $\mathbf{s}^{(0)} \odot (\mathbf{X} \ast_{\text{dw}} \mathbf{W}^{(0)} + b) + R^{(1)}$   $\triangleright$  base path + reconstruction
```

2.2 Haar transform differentiation

For each non-overlapping 2×2 block, the normalised Haar transform maps four input samples to four subband coefficients using the following matrix.

Proposition 1 (Symmetry and self-inversion). $\mathbf{H} = \frac{1}{2} \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 & -1 & -1 \\ 1 & -1 & 1 & -1 \\ 1 & -1 & -1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$ satisfies $\mathbf{H}^\top = \mathbf{H}$ and $\mathbf{H}^2 = \mathbf{I}$. Therefore, $\mathbf{H}^{-1} = \mathbf{H}^\top = \mathbf{H}$.

The full analysis operator $\mathcal{A}$ applies $\mathbf{H}$ independently to every block, and synthesis applies $\mathcal{A}^\top$. For $\mathbf{y} = \mathbf{H}\mathbf{x}$, the chain rule gives

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \mathbf{x}} = \mathbf{H}^\top \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \mathbf{y}} = \mathbf{H} \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \mathbf{y}}. \quad (1)$$

Thus, backward through analysis applies synthesis, and backward through synthesis applies analysis. The Haar step needs no separate derivative; convolution and scale gradients are computed as usual.

2.3 The roofline

The roofline model (Williams et al., 2009) bounds attainable throughput by $\min(\pi, \beta I)$ where π is peak compute, β peak bandwidth, and I the arithmetic intensity in FLOP/byte. The ridge point $I^* = \pi/\beta$ separates memory-bound from compute-bound operation. For the RTX A6000 used throughout, $\beta = 768$ GB/s and $\pi \approx 38.7$ TFLOP/s in `fp32`, so $I^* \approx 50$ FLOP/byte. Any operator with $I \ll I^*$ is bandwidth-limited: its runtime is governed by the bytes it moves rather than by how the arithmetic is scheduled. The bound is an upper bound on attainable throughput and not an equality, so this identifies traffic as the quantity to minimise without implying that runtime is proportional to it. The practical content of this paper is that

WTConv is deeply in that regime, so minimising traffic is not merely one optimisation among many: it is the whole problem.

3 WTConv is memory-bound

3.1 I/O cost of the reference implementation

The reference implementation expresses each level as a chain of framework primitives, every one of which reads its input from HBM and writes its output back (Figure 1a). We count elements crossing the HBM boundary: each stage reads its input tensor once and writes its output tensor once, weight traffic is $\mathcal{O}(Ck^2)$ and therefore negligible against $\mathcal{O}(N)$. Writing $N_\ell = N/4^{\ell-1}$ for the element count entering level ℓ :

- *Analysis*, per level: the Haar transform is executed as a grouped stride-2 `conv2d` against a constant $\pm\frac{1}{2}$ filter ($2N_\ell$); the depthwise convolution over the $4C$ -channel coefficient tensor ($2N_\ell$); the scale multiply ($2N_\ell$). Total $6N_\ell$.
- *Synthesis*, per level: the cross-level low-pass add ($\frac{3}{4}N_\ell$); the concatenation of the summed low-pass band with the three high bands ($2N_\ell$); the `conv_transpose2d` ($2N_\ell$). Total $\frac{19}{4}N_\ell$.
- *Base path*: convolution ($2N$), scale multiply ($2N$), final add ($3N$). Total $7N$.

Using $\sum_{\ell=1}^L 4^{-(\ell-1)} = \frac{4}{3}(1 - 4^{-L})$,

$$Q_{\text{ref}} = 7N + \left(6 + \frac{19}{4}\right) \cdot \frac{4}{3} N(1 - 4^{-L}) = 7N + \frac{43}{3} N(1 - 4^{-L}), \quad (2)$$

rising from $17.75N$ at $L = 1$ to $21.33N$ as $L \rightarrow \infty$; that is, evaluating the layer moves between 18 and 21 times the input tensor’s worth of data through HBM. For a representative $B=8$, $C=64$, $H=W=256$ input, $N = 33.6\text{M}$ elements (128 MiB in `fp32`) and the reference therefore moves roughly 2.9 GB per forward pass.

3.2 Arithmetic intensity of the reference implementation

The base convolution performs k^2 multiply–accumulates per element. At level ℓ , the depthwise convolution over the coefficient tensor costs a further k^2 per element of N_ℓ , and the analysis and synthesis each cost 4, since the reference executes both as 2×2 convolutions rather than as additions. Summing over levels with the same geometric factor as before,

$$\text{MAC} = N[k^2 + (k^2 + 8) \cdot \frac{4}{3}(1 - 4^{-L})]. \quad (3)$$

For $k = 3$ and $L = 5$ this is $31.6N$ multiply–accumulates, or $63.3N$ FLOPs, against $4Q_{\text{ref}} = 85.3N$ bytes in `fp32`:

$$I_{\text{ref}} = \frac{63.3N}{85.3N} \approx 0.74 \text{ FLOP/byte}. \quad (4)$$

Against the ridge point $I^* \approx 50$ (subsection 2.3), WTConv therefore sits almost $70\times$ to the left of the ridge, using under 2% of the machine’s arithmetic capability. The arithmetic is not the problem: no amount of faster transform evaluation would help, and only removing traffic can.

4 An I/O-Aware formulation

To eliminate the severe memory bottleneck of the reference WTConv (Equation (2)), we derive an I/O-aware formulation based on three exact algebraic reformulations. These reformulations leave the underlying mathematical operator unchanged, differing from the reference implementation solely in floating-point evaluation order. Together, they eliminate all large intermediate subband tensors from high-bandwidth memory (HBM) by performing multi-stage computations directly in GPU registers and shared memory across all decomposition levels.

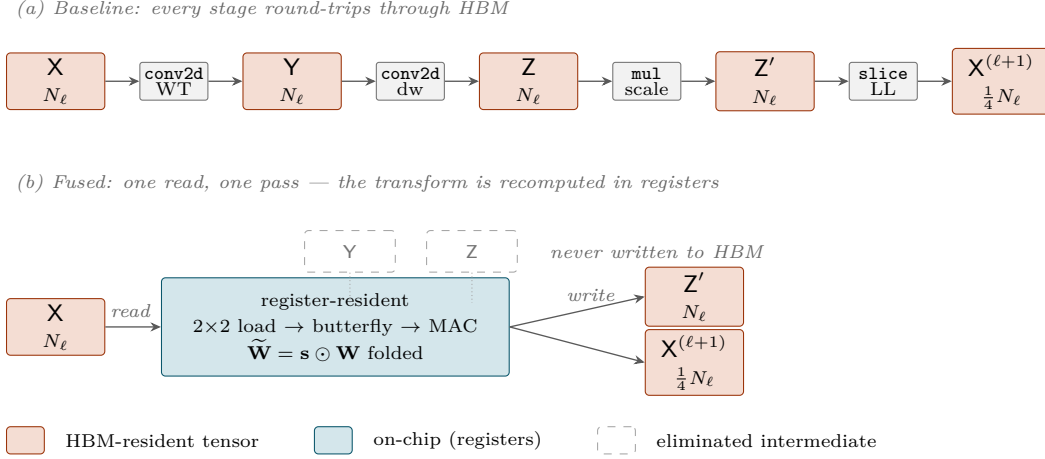


Figure 1: HBM dataflow for one WTConv decomposition level ℓ , with $N_\ell = N/4^{\ell-1}$ the number of elements entering that level. (a) The reference implementation expresses the level as a chain of framework primitives; every stage materialises a full-size tensor in HBM. (b) The fused formulation reads the input once, evaluates the Haar butterfly and the depthwise convolution on chip against weights that already carry the learned scale, and writes only the results. Y and Z are never written,

4.1 Register-resident Haar analysis

For a 2×2 spatial patch $\begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$, the normalized 2D Haar analysis transform maps four input pixels to subband coefficients (LL, LH, HL, HH) via:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{LL} &= \frac{1}{2}(a + b + c + d), & \text{LH} &= \frac{1}{2}(a + b - c - d), \\ \text{HL} &= \frac{1}{2}(a - b + c - d), & \text{HH} &= \frac{1}{2}(a - b - c + d). \end{aligned} \quad (5)$$

Evaluating Equation (5) requires only additions and scaling by $\frac{1}{2}$, with zero floating-point multiplications. In contrast, the reference implementation materializes the entire coefficient tensor $Y^{(\ell)}$ in HBM via grouped convolutions with $\pm \frac{1}{2}$ filters.

Reference. Each level runs Haar analysis, depthwise convolution, and learned scaling as separate passes. Each pass reads and writes an N_ℓ -element tensor, moving $6N_\ell$ elements in total. *Fused.* Our kernel computes the Haar coefficients inside the depthwise convolution and folds the scale into its weights (Section 4.3). Because WTConv reaches only 0.74 FLOP/byte (Section 3), recomputing the coefficients is much cheaper than materialising them in HBM.

Naive fusion would recompute the transform for every convolution tap and load each input pixel k^2 times. Instead, each thread block transforms the 2×2 blocks for one output tile, including a coefficient-space halo of radius $R = (k - 1)/2$, and stages the four subbands in shared memory. All taps reuse this copy, so each block is transformed once per tile. Except at the deepest level, the fused kernel reads N_ℓ input elements, writes N_ℓ filtered coefficients for synthesis, and writes $\frac{1}{4}N_\ell$ unfiltered low-pass coefficients for the next level. It therefore moves $\frac{9}{4}N_\ell$ elements, versus $6N_\ell$ for the reference. The deepest level has no successor and moves $2N_L$. This model counts each halo position once; neighbouring tiles may re-fetch it, usually from L2. Thus, N_ℓ is a lower bound on input reads, not an exact device-level count.

4.2 Collapsing the synthesis cascade

The reference implementation executes reconstruction as an L -step sequential loop, where each level reads the lower-level reconstruction from HBM, adds it to its low-pass subband, and applies transposed convolution. This imposes L strict sequential dependencies and incurs an I/O cost of $\frac{19}{4}N_\ell$ per level.

Because Haar synthesis is linear, the low-pass carrier acts as a linear accumulator across levels. As a result, the multi-level synthesis cascade can be collapsed into a single closed-form pass across all L levels. Haar synthesis at level ℓ expands each subband coefficient over a $2^\ell \times 2^\ell$ pixel block using a fixed sign pattern determined by the spatial location of the output pixel within that block.

Proposition 2 (Bit-indexed single-pass synthesis). *Let (y, x) denote an output pixel coordinate, and let level $\ell \in \{1, \dots, L\}$ have subband coefficients $(c_{LL}^{(\ell)}, c_{LH}^{(\ell)}, c_{HL}^{(\ell)}, c_{HH}^{(\ell)})$ at coarse grid location $(\lfloor y/2^\ell \rfloor, \lfloor x/2^\ell \rfloor)$. Define the coordinate parity signs at level ℓ as:*

$$s_y^{(\ell)} = (-1)^{\lfloor y/2^{\ell-1} \rfloor \bmod 2}, \quad s_x^{(\ell)} = (-1)^{\lfloor x/2^{\ell-1} \rfloor \bmod 2}. \quad (6)$$

The reconstructed pixel value $R_{y,x}$ across all L levels is given by:

$$R_{y,x} = \sum_{\ell=1}^L 2^{-\ell} \left(c_{LL}^{(\ell)} + s_y^{(\ell)} c_{LH}^{(\ell)} + s_x^{(\ell)} c_{HL}^{(\ell)} + s_y^{(\ell)} s_x^{(\ell)} c_{HH}^{(\ell)} \right). \quad (7)$$

By evaluating Equation (7) in a single pass, a GPU thread computing pixel (y, x) iterates from level L down to 1, addressing coarse coefficients via coordinate bit-shifts and obtaining signs through bitwise parity checks. This eliminates all intermediate low-pass tensors and sequential kernel dependencies. Furthermore, the base-path convolution output is folded directly into the final output store, eliminating a separate full-resolution tensor addition.

4.3 Folding the learned scale

The reference implementation applies learned per-channel scaling s_c after convolution ($Z_c = s_c(\mathbf{X} *_{\text{dw}} \mathbf{W})_c$) as a standalone elementwise pass. At an arithmetic intensity of $\frac{1}{4}$ FLOP/byte, this pass severely limits memory throughput.

By the linearity of convolution, the scale factor can be folded directly into the depthwise weights:

$$\widetilde{\mathbf{W}}_c = s_c \odot \mathbf{W}_c. \quad (8)$$

This allows $\mathbf{Z} = \mathbf{X} *_{\text{dw}} \widetilde{\mathbf{W}}$ to be computed in a single pass with zero extra runtime cost. The weight folding is performed on host memory with negligible cost $\mathcal{O}(Ck^2)$.

During backpropagation, exact parameter gradients with respect to the unscaled weight $\mathbf{W}_c$ and scale s_c are efficiently recovered via:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \mathbf{W}_c} = s_c \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \widetilde{\mathbf{W}}_c}, \quad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial s_c} = \left\langle \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \widetilde{\mathbf{W}}_c}, \mathbf{W}_c \right\rangle. \quad (9)$$

4.4 The resulting I/O cost

Collecting the reformulations across all levels $1 \dots L$, with $N_\ell = N/4^{\ell-1}$:

- *Base path*: the folded vendor convolution reads N and writes N ($2N$).
- *Analysis & Depthwise pass*, levels $1 \leq \ell \leq L$: reads N_ℓ , writes N_ℓ convolved coefficients and $\frac{1}{4}N_\ell$ raw low-pass coefficients ($\frac{9}{4}N_\ell$ each, less the $\frac{1}{4}N_L$ the deepest level does not write).
- *Single-pass Synthesis*: reads all subband coefficients $\sum_{\ell=1}^L N_\ell$ and base-path output N , writing the final output N ($\sum_{\ell=1}^L N_\ell + 2N$).

Using $\sum_{\ell=1}^L N_\ell = \frac{4}{3}N(1 - 4^{-L})$, the total memory traffic is:

$$Q_{\text{fused}} = 4N + \frac{13}{3}N(1 - 4^{-L}) - \frac{1}{4}N4^{1-L}. \quad (10)$$

Comparing this to the reference memory traffic Q_{ref} (Equation (2)), the theoretical reduction ratio in HBM data movement is:

$$\frac{Q_{\text{ref}}}{Q_{\text{fused}}} = \frac{7 + \frac{43}{3}(1 - 4^{-L})}{4 + \frac{13}{3}(1 - 4^{-L})} \xrightarrow{L \rightarrow \infty} \frac{64}{25} = 2.56. \quad (11)$$

As $L \rightarrow \infty$, the fused formulation achieves up to a $2.56\times$ reduction in memory traffic over the reference implementation. Table 1 summarizes the exact element counts and traffic reduction ratios for decomposition levels $L = 1 \dots 5$.

Table 1: Elements crossing the HBM boundary per forward evaluation, in units of $N = B \cdot C \cdot H \cdot W$, from Equation (2), Equation (10), and Equation (11). The last row is a ratio of *traffic*, not of runtime; see the discussion below.

	Decomposition levels L				
	1	2	3	4	5
Reference, Q_{ref}	$17.75N$	$20.44N$	$21.11N$	$21.28N$	$21.32N$
Fused, Q_{fused}	$7.00N$	$7.94N$	$8.19N$	$8.25N$	$8.27N$
Traffic removed	$2.54\times$	$2.57\times$	$2.58\times$	$2.58\times$	$2.58\times$

5 Related work

Large receptive fields in CNNs. The effective receptive field of a deep CNN grows only as $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{n})$ in depth (Luo et al., 2016), motivating dilation (Yu & Koltun, 2016) and directly enlarged kernels (Ding et al., 2022; Liu et al., 2023), which pay in parameters and FLOPs. WTConv (Finder et al., 2024) instead makes parameters logarithmic in the receptive field. This literature optimises parameters and FLOPs; our point is that for WTConv neither quantity is what determines runtime.

Wavelets in deep learning. Multiresolution analysis and the filter-bank algorithm (Mallat, 1989) on the Haar basis (Haar, 1910) underpin a line of work using the DWT as an aliasing-free replacement for pooling and downsampling (Williams & Li, 2018; Li et al., 2020) and as a multi-scale backbone for restoration (Liu et al., 2018). All of these invoke the transform through a framework `conv2d`, treating it as a fixed primitive. We treat it instead as a fusion boundary to be dissolved.

Fast wavelet transforms. The lifting scheme factors a wavelet transform into in-place prediction and update steps (Sweldens, 1996; 1998; Daubechies & Sweldens, 1998), reducing operation count and enabling in-place evaluation; GPU implementations have long compared filter-bank against lifting formulations (Tenllado et al., 2008). That literature optimises the transform in isolation. The transform is not the bottleneck here: our gain comes from fusing it into the surrounding convolution so that it never touches memory at all, and for Haar specifically the lifting factorisation coincides with the butterfly of Equation (5).

Kernel fusion and memory-bound operators. That data movement rather than arithmetic limits deep learning is well established (Ivanov et al., 2021; Wahib & Maruyama, 2014), and FlashAttention (Dao et al., 2022; Dao, 2024) is the canonical demonstration that an exact reassociation which keeps intermediates on chip can transform an operator’s practical cost. Our work is the same argument applied to a different operator, with the additional structure that the transform being fused is multiplication-free, symmetric, and self-inverse. These properties make recomputation inexpensive and let analysis and synthesis exchange roles during backpropagation. General-purpose compilers (Ragan-Kelley et al., 2013; Chen et al., 2018; Sabne, 2020; Ansel et al., 2024) automate fusion of elementwise and reduction chains, but the reassociations of Section 4.2, collapsing an L -step recursion into a closed-form bit-indexed sum, rest on properties of the Haar basis that a general compiler does not have access to.

Depthwise convolution efficiency. Depthwise convolutions have low arithmetic intensity and are known to underutilise GPUs relative to their FLOP count (Howard et al., 2017; Ma et al., 2018; Lu et al., 2022). WTConv inherits this and compounds it with a per-level chain of full-tensor intermediates.

6 Limitations

Scope of the kernels. They implement Haar (db1) only. The reference layer accepts any PyWavelets family, and a model trained with db2 or longer cannot use our kernels. The multiplication-free argument of Section 4.1 is specific to Haar; longer filters would still admit the reformulation but with a materially worse recompute trade. We also require depthwise operation with $C_{\text{in}} = C_{\text{out}}$, odd k , and $L \leq 5$ (the last is a hand-unrolled dispatch limit, not an algorithmic one).

Compilation. All results are eager-mode on both arms. Our layer opts out of Dynamo tracing, so we cannot report a fair `torch.compile` comparison; an inductor-generated fusion of the reference is a baseline this paper does not measure, and a reviewer is right to want it. We expect inductor to fuse the elementwise scale but not to discover Proposition 2.

Measurement. Single-layer microbenchmarks on one GPU per platform, with a fixed resident input tensor and no host-to-device transfer. We report geometric means over the configuration sweep and per-iteration dispersion, but no cross-machine replication. All reported ratios are layer-level, and Amdahl’s law applies: a $2.5\times$ layer speedup yields a smaller whole-model speedup, and we do not report an end-to-end training measurement here.

Shift-variance. As is already true of the reference operator, the 2^ℓ -aligned decomposition grid makes WTConv equivariant only to translations by multiples of 2^L . Our reformulation is exactly equivalent, so it neither introduces nor removes this property.

Backend maturity. The Metal comparison is against PyTorch’s MPS backend, which is considerably less mature than cuDNN; the Apple-side ratios should be read as a portability demonstration, not as a like-for-like vendor comparison.

7 Conclusion

WTConv’s difficulty was never its arithmetic. Expressed as a chain of framework primitives it runs at under 2% of a modern GPU’s arithmetic capability, spending its time moving tensors that need never have existed. Accounting for those bytes exactly, and removing them with three algebraic identities (a register-resident multiplication-free analysis, a synthesis cascade collapsed into a bit-indexed closed form, and a scale folded into the weights), yields a bit-exact reformulation whose cost is within a small constant of the compulsory traffic. We do not claim that the ratio of bytes predicts the ratio of seconds; what the account buys is the identification of the quantity to remove, and that the same identities reproduce the gain on two other stacks suggests the identification is the right one. The broader point is that an operator’s asymptotic parameter or FLOP advantage says little about whether it is usable; for the growing class of layers built from cheap, structured, multi-stage transforms, the I/O cost model is the one that predicts practice.

Broader Impact Statement

This work reduces the time and energy required to evaluate an existing operator without changing its function; the primary effect is lower computational cost for practitioners already using WTConv. We see no application-specific ethical concerns beyond those already attached to efficient computer vision generally.

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A Reproducibility

Every number in this paper is produced by a script in the accompanying artifact, and no value is transcribed into the manuscript by hand: the benchmark scripts emit JSON, a table generator turns that JSON into the $\text{\LaTeX}$ fragments the paper `\inputs`, and re-running the pipeline overwrites the tables in place.

A.1 Pipeline

```
python scripts/bench.py          --device cuda --mode both \
                                --out results/bench_cuda.json
python scripts/correctness.py    --device cuda \
                                --out results/correctness.json
python scripts/make_tables.py    --bench results/bench_cuda.json \
                                --correctness results/correctness.json
```

`scripts/common.py` holds the measurement harness and the weight synchronisation used by both entry points; `scripts/bench.py` sweeps the configuration grid; `scripts/correctness.py` performs the equivalence tests; `scripts/make_tables.py` renders the tables.

A.2 Measurement protocol

Timing. CUDA events bracket each individual iteration, so device time is measured rather than host-side launch time, and the distribution over iterations is retained rather than only its mean. Each configuration runs 20 warmup iterations — enough to cover JIT compilation, Triton autotuning and cuDNN algorithm selection — followed by 50 timed iterations. We report the geometric mean of per-configuration ratios over the sweep; the raw JSON also carries median, standard deviation and the 10th/90th percentiles for every configuration, which we recommend inspecting before quoting any single figure.

Memory. `torch.cuda.reset_peak_memory_stats` followed by one untimed step and `torch.cuda.max_memory_allocated`. This measures allocator high-water mark, not reserved memory.

Weight synchronisation. Correctness comparisons construct a reference module and a fused module from the same seed and then copy every learnable tensor from the former into the latter, so the two modules are the same function. The base path maps `base_conv.weight/.bias/base_scale.weight` onto the fused module’s corresponding parameters, and level ℓ maps `wavelet_convs[l].weight` and `wavelet_scale[l].weight`. The subband axis is packed identically in both (channel = $4c + s$ with $s \in (\text{LL}, \text{LH}, \text{HL}, \text{HH})$); rather than assume this, `correctness.py` drives the reference’s own filter bank with a one-hot 2×2 patch and checks the resulting coefficient order and signs against Eq. (5).

Cotangent. Backward comparisons use a fixed random cotangent rather than `.sum()`, which would leave sign-cancelling errors undetected.

Tolerances. `fp32` is held to $\text{atol} = 10^{-5}$, $\text{rtol} = 10^{-4}$; `fp16` to $2 \times 10^{-2}/10^{-2}$; `bf16` to $10^{-1}/5 \times 10^{-2}$. These follow from the accumulated rounding of a k^2 -term dot product in the respective format rather than being tuned to make the test pass. We note that an absolute tolerance of 10^{-7} , sometimes quoted for comparisons of this kind, is not attainable for a multi-level accumulation in `fp32` and should not be expected.

A.3 Configuration grid

$C \in \{32, 64, 128\}$; $H = W \in \{128, 256, 512\}$; batch size 8; $L \in \{1, \dots, 5\}$; $k = 3$ for WTConv and, under the homogeneous protocol, for the plain-convolution baselines; $k = 7$ for the plain-convolution baselines under the receptive-field-matched protocol; **fp32**, **fp16** and **bf16**. Baselines: *depthwise* is `nn.Conv2d(C, C, k, groups=C, padding='same')` and *dense* is `nn.Conv2d(C, C, k, padding='same')`.

A.4 Environment

The environment record (GPU, compute capability, HBM capacity, PyTorch, CUDA, cuDNN and Triton versions) is captured automatically into every results JSON and rendered into the manuscript by the table generator, so the reported hardware cannot drift from the hardware actually used.

A.5 Claim-to-evidence map

Claim	Evidence
Haar analysis is self-inverse and self-adjoint	Proposition 1; verified exactly over the rationals by <code>correctness.py</code>
Single-pass synthesis	Proposition 2
Reference moves $7N + \frac{43}{3}N(1 - 4^{-L})$ elements	Per-primitive accounting, Section 3, read off the reference implementation stage by stage
Operator is bandwidth-bound	$I \in [0.44, 0.89]$ FLOP/byte against $I^* \approx 50$, Section 3
Fusion is exact, not approximate	Each step is an algebraic identity; residuals reported by <code>correctness.py</code> against the tolerances above
Fused form moves $7N$ ($L=1$) to $8.27N$ elements	Per-stage accounting, Section 4.4; not converted into a predicted latency ratio
Measured speedup	Table 2, against the reference and against plain convolutions at matched receptive field
Portability	Table 3

A.6 Known gaps

For transparency we list what the artifact does *not* establish. There is no accuracy result connecting the fused kernels to a downstream task, and this paper reports no end-to-end training measurement: every reported ratio is layer-level. There is no `torch.compile` arm on either side. Timing uses a single resident input tensor, so no host-to-device transfer or data loading is included. Each platform is represented by one device.

B Receptive-field-matched comparison

Comparing every method at the same kernel size isolates the cost of the wavelet machinery, but it is not the comparison a practitioner faces. WTConv is proposed as a replacement for a *large* convolution: an L -level layer at $k=3$ reaches $3 \cdot 2^L$ pixels, so even $L=2$ already exceeds the footprint of a 7×7 kernel. Table 2 therefore reports the measurement with the plain-convolution baselines at $k=7$, all ratios taken against the reference WTConv.

The comparison changes the verdict on the operator. Against a dense 7×7 convolution the reference WTConv is 1.14–1.65 $\times$ slower in **fp32**, so on wall-clock grounds it is the worse choice despite its parameter advantage; the fused layer is 1.75–1.96 $\times$ faster than that same dense convolution at every level. Against a depthwise 7×7 convolution, a much cheaper baseline that does not mix channels, the fused layer is roughly at parity in **fp32** and ahead in **fp16**. We report the depthwise column for completeness rather than as the intended substitution, since a depthwise 7×7 layer is not functionally interchangeable with a dense one.

Table 2: Receptive-field-matched comparison: WTConv at $k=3$ against plain convolutions at $k=7$, all relative to the reference WTConv (1.00 $\times$; higher is faster), CUDA backend on an RTX A6000. The reference WTConv is *slower* than the dense convolution it is meant to replace; the fused layer is faster than it at every level.

Method	Precision	Decomposition levels L				
		1	2	3	4	5
Depthwise conv, $k=7$	fp32	2.07 $\times$	2.72 $\times$	2.89 $\times$	2.96 $\times$	3.01 $\times$
	fp16	1.39 $\times$	1.82 $\times$	1.94 $\times$	2.03 $\times$	2.06 $\times$
Dense conv, $k=7$	fp32	1.14 $\times$	1.49 $\times$	1.59 $\times$	1.62 $\times$	1.65 $\times$
	fp16	1.29 $\times$	1.68 $\times$	1.80 $\times$	1.87 $\times$	1.90 $\times$
WTConv, reference	fp32	1.00 $\times$	1.00 $\times$	1.00 $\times$	1.00 $\times$	1.00 $\times$
	fp16	1.00 $\times$	1.00 $\times$	1.00 $\times$	1.00 $\times$	1.00 $\times$
WTConv, fused	fp32	2.24 $\times$	2.72 $\times$	2.83 $\times$	2.87 $\times$	2.89 $\times$
	fp16	2.96 $\times$	3.62 $\times$	3.77 $\times$	3.85 $\times$	3.84 $\times$

Table 3: Speedup over the reference implementation for all three realisations of the same reformulation, homogeneous protocol ($k=3$). The Metal figures are measured against PyTorch’s MPS backend, which is markedly less mature than cuDNN; they demonstrate portability of the formulation rather than a like-for-like vendor comparison.

Backend	Hardware	Precision	Decomposition levels L				
			1	2	3	4	5
CUDA	RTX A6000	fp32	2.24 $\times$	2.72 $\times$	2.82 $\times$	2.85 $\times$	2.87 $\times$
		fp16	2.99 $\times$	3.65 $\times$	3.79 $\times$	3.83 $\times$	3.84 $\times$
Triton	RTX A6000	fp32	2.71 $\times$	3.09 $\times$	3.03 $\times$	2.90 $\times$	2.81 $\times$
		fp16	2.94 $\times$	3.16 $\times$	3.00 $\times$	2.81 $\times$	2.69 $\times$
Metal	M3 Pro	fp32	2.05 $\times$	2.34 $\times$	2.40 $\times$	2.37 $\times$	2.31 $\times$
		fp16	2.05 $\times$	2.13 $\times$	2.20 $\times$	2.20 $\times$	2.15 $\times$

C Other backends

The reformulation of Section 4 is stated in terms of algebra and memory traffic, so it carries over to any accelerator whose cost is dominated by traffic to a large, slow memory. We re-derived the same two kernels twice more as a test of that claim. Table 3 collects the results.

C.1 Triton

The Triton realisation (Tillet et al., 2019) expresses the register-resident analysis of Section 4 directly: for each coefficient position the kernel iterates the $k \times k$ tap grid with `tl.static_range`, addresses the corresponding 2×2 input block, forms the four subband values, and accumulates into four **fp32** vectors. Because the kernel loads a compact four-element weight vector per tap rather than an effective $(C, 4, k, k)$ kernel per output, its weight traffic is a quarter of the naive fused form. Block size, warp count and pipeline depth are left to autotuning over eleven configurations keyed on problem size.

The backward pass mirrors the forward: it iterates the same grid, applies the transposed butterfly to the incoming subband gradients, and writes to a *disjoint* 2×2 input block per thread, so no atomics are required for ∇_X . Weight and scale gradients use Eq. (9) over recomputed coefficients.

Performance matches the CUDA realisation closely — slightly ahead in **fp32** (2.71–3.09 $\times$ against 2.24–2.89 $\times$) and slightly behind in **fp16** — which is the expected outcome if both are limited by the same traffic. Two

practical differences are worth recording. Triton’s JIT removes the dependency on a local `nvcc` installation, and its autotuner adapts block sizes to the device without hand-tuning. Against that, the kernel specialises on tensor shape, so a workload with many distinct shapes pays repeated compilation, and the layer opts out of Dynamo tracing, so it cannot currently be captured by `torch.compile`.

C.2 Apple Metal

The Metal realisation targets Apple Silicon through PyTorch’s MPS backend. The forward cascade uses a 16×16 threadgroup per 32×32 input tile, staging the low-pass band in a single threadgroup buffer that is aliased and overwritten in place at each level ($256 \rightarrow 64 \rightarrow 16 \rightarrow 4$ floats) with threads retiring geometrically between barriers. The inverse cascade follows Proposition 2 per thread, exactly as in CUDA. As on NVIDIA, `fp16` kernels convert to `fp32` on load, keep all butterflies and all cross-level accumulation in `fp32`, and round once at the store; the inter-level threadgroup buffer is `fp32` regardless of input precision.

Measured speedups are 2.05–2.40 $\times$. Three caveats attach to these numbers and we would not want them read as a vendor comparison. First, the baseline is PyTorch’s generic MPS backend, which is substantially less mature than cuDNN; this inflates the Apple-side ratios, and the dense-convolution column in particular ($5\times$ – $13\times$ slower than the fused layer) reflects the maturity of the baseline far more than it reflects our kernels. Second, the current dispatch issues a full stream synchronisation before encoding each operation, which serialises host and device and makes these figures pessimistic for end-to-end throughput on both arms. Third, several inverse dispatches currently launch single-thread threadgroups, so occupancy is far below what the formulation permits — the Metal numbers should be read as a lower bound on what the reformulation can deliver on this hardware rather than as a tuned result.

C.3 Coverage

The CUDA and Triton paths support `fp32`, `fp16` and `bf16`; the Metal path supports `fp32` and `fp16` only. All three implement Haar with $L \leq 5$, depthwise, $C_{\text{in}} = C_{\text{out}}$, and odd k .